

"That is one of Gowda's many qualities—family comes first."

SIDDARAMAIAH, FORMER DEPUTY CHIEF MINISTER



THE BETRAYED: BJP leader Ananth Kumar (in brown) at a rally

and the MLAs for deserting the Congress and hurting his "secular" credentials by aligning with BJP, Gowda did not follow up on his threats seriously. He could have suspended them and disqualified the MLAs but he just complained to the Speaker who was also from the JD(S). The Speaker is sitting on his decision even today as the Assembly is in suspended animation. The Centre has already endorsed Karnataka Governor Rameshwar Thakur's recommendation for President's rule but the JD(S) is still hoping it can strike a deal with the Congress to stay in power after BJP ruled out any move to patch up with Deve Gowda.

Both Kumaraswamy and his brother public works minister H.D. Revanna have always taken decisions after consulting their father. Of Gowda's four sons, two are in active politics, one took premature retirement from the state civil service and the youngest continues as a doctor. "I respect my father as he is my philoso-

pher and guide. Without him, I would not be in politics today, or in a position of leadership," says Kumaraswamy, who resigned on October 8 after failing to strike a pact with BJP to continue in power. "Anyone hurting my son, who did a commendable job as a chief minister,... I will not take it lightly," says Gowda, referring to the FIR filed against Kumaraswamy by a local BJP leader, which became one of the flashpoints in the power struggle. "I am surprised even the central BJP leadership did not react the way I thought they would, when their party members were humiliating him", adds Gowda. Says his close friend-turned-foe Siddaramaiah, "That is one of the qualities about him. Family comes first."

Kumaraswamy was goaded by his legislators to transfer power to BJP as per an earlier agreement, but his brother Revanna and Gowda were firmly against giving in to the "communal" party, with the former prime minister suddenly mouthing "secularist" rhetoric. Happy with the BJP-JD(S) coalition government for 20

months, Gowda suddenly changed his stance after BJP played hardball with him. "You never know what he is up to," says a former Gowda aide PGR Sindhia, who was once projected as a potential chief minister but was disowned quickly. "Gowda does not keep his word at all and does not mind speaking with a forked tongue."

He can be vindictive too. Gowda would never forget the insult when the late Ramakrishna Hegde, his mentor and the leader who first made him a minister, ordered an investigation into his PWD ministry following allegations of corruption. When Gowda became prime minister, he promptly threw Hegde out of the party and never made up with him.

Long-time rival in the Congress and fellow member of the Vokkaliga community, D.K. Shivakumar also has a tale to tell. He was denied a minister's post when Gowda was the power behind the Dharam Singh-led Congress-JD(S) coalition government. Shivakumar had earlier engineered defeats for Gowda in the Lok Sabha constituency of Kanakapura and for